crashed into a densely built urban area, the consequences could have been catastrophic—a risk underscored by the June 2025 crash of Air India flight AI171, a Boeing 787-8 Dreamliner that came down on a hostel building shortly after take-off in Ahmedabad, killing 241 people on board and 19 on the ground.

THE INSIDER PROBLEM

The latest incident exposes a difficult gap in aviation security. "There is nothing in the training modules that can prepare a pilot for his co-pilot going rogue and attacking him," says Captain Sam Thomas, president of the Airline Pilots' Association of India. Post-9/11, the reinforced cockpit door became the principal barrier against an attacker trying to gain access. A decade ago, Germanwings Flight 9525 showed what happens when the threat is already inside. On March 24, 2015, its captain left the cockpit while flying over the French Alps. The co-pilot remained inside, locked the door, initiated a descent and prevented the captain from re-entering. All 150 people aboard the Airbus A320 died when it struck the mountainside.

Europe responded with stronger psychological assessment, aeromedical oversight and pilot-support programmes. India's framework is different. Captain C.S. Randhawa, president of the Federation of Indian Pilots, says, "In many countries, a psychometry test of pilots is mandatory during induction. In India, it is not...airlines do it on their own, as part of their processes." Representatives of Indian carriers contacted for this story, who spoke on condition that their airlines not be named, said "all that can be done"—psychological tests, background checks and other screening during induction—is being done.

THE WARNING GAP

FZ1073 raises another question: what happens when red flags exist but do not travel with the person they concern? The 29-year-old Omani co-pilot had reportedly been removed from flight training at Oman Air and barred from flying in Oman over security concerns relating to his radical ideological views. He subsequently passed vetting in the UAE and had worked for Flydubai for eight months before the incident. That points to two gaps. Pilots can move between airlines and jurisdictions, while intelligence and security information may not move with them. And psychological instruments designed primarily to identify clinical mental health or cognitive disorders may not reliably detect ideological radicalisation.

India's Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) mandates periodic Class 1 aeromedical certification for commercial pilots. Examiners are expected to pay particular attention to depression, anxiety, panic disorders and substance misuse. Operators are also encouraged to use validated psychological tools during recruitment. But there is no EASA (European Union Aviation Safety Agency)-equivalent universal requirement for a separate operator-level psychological assessment before a pilot begins flying scheduled operations. The DGCA itself recognised the limits of universal testing in the medical circular that came into effect on May 31, 2023. It said comprehensive psychiatric evaluation of every pilot at every periodic medical examination would not be productive or cost-effective because serious psychiatric illness is difficult to predict. Instead, it called for quicker mental health assessment during routine medicals.

CLOSING THE GAPS

What can go wrong—and what needs to be done to keep a rogue pilot from turning an aircraft into a weapon



↘RED FLAGS MISSED: Warning signs may not surface during recruitment; risks like substance misuse, debt, coercion may develop later

THE FIX Continuous vetting: Reassess pilots throughout their careers through random testing and risk assessment



↘PSYCHOLOGICAL TESTS FALL SHORT: They may not reveal radicalisation or hostile intent

THE FIX Broader screening: Combine medical, psychological and behavioural checks with intelligence inputs



↘PILOT HIDES INFORMATION: Fear of losing their licence may deter pilots from disclosing mental health issues

THE FIX Make seeking help safer: Ensure confidential peer support, treatment and clear rules for doctors to report risks



↘THE CHAIN BREAKS: Security warnings may not follow a pilot between airlines or countries

THE FIX Share intelligence: Facilitate legally authorised information-sharing across airlines, regulators and security agencies



↘THE THREAT IS INSIDE: Conventional security is designed primarily to keep unauthorised people out

THE FIX Plan for insider threats: Strengthen cockpit-cabin coordination and emergency response